



AMD unveils Ryzen 7000 chips

AMD has introduced new Ryzen 7000 series desktop processors powered by "Zen 4" architecture. <https://digit.in/sep22-47>



iPhone 14 with 30W fast charging

The iPhone 14 lineup may arrive with 30W fast charging, a significant jump from 20W on the 13 series. <https://digit.in/sep22-48>

Sony LinkBuds

A unique experience

Sony took the leap and launched their LinkBuds in India, pricing them at ₹19,990. This is the latest addition to Sony's line of premium earbuds. With their unique design and approach towards giving the users a new audio listening and calling experience, they do stand out. The question is, are they good enough to stand up to the standards set by others? Let's find out.

BUILD, DESIGN, AND FIT

The Sony Linkbuds have anything but a mainstream design, and wearing them is a statement. When it comes to the fit of the earbuds, things start getting tricky. They are small and lightweight. However, given their 8-shaped design language, the fit is either a hit or a miss. Even with their silicon loop, which is meant to hold the buds in place, if your ears are small, then these might not fit you.

In terms of the case, Sony trumps most other TWS makers out there. The case is really small and has great pocketability. The branding is subtle, just like on the buds themselves. However, the overall feel of the case is flimsy, and with no metal bracket support, you could easily break the lid of the case. And, if you like opening your earbuds case with one hand, good luck. You have to press a button in the front to open up the case.

FEATURES

What Sony loses out in terms of the design and build of the case and the fit of the buds, it makes up for it in the features department. Apart from the regular inclusions like in-ear detection and others, the two features that stand out the most are – adaptive volume control and wide area tap.

Let's start with the wide-area tap. What this does is that it extends the touch-sensitive area from the buds over to the region in front of the ears. So,



you can tap on your skin to change tracks. While this may seem like a gimmicky feature at first glance, the actual performance is way above par. The second on the list is the adaptive volume control which automatically changes the volume levels depending upon the ambient noise. This feature, just like the wide-area tap, outperformed our expectations.

However, the way that these buds are designed, they miss out on what has become a staple in premium earbuds, active noise cancellation. These earbuds lack ANC and often let too much ambient noise in due to the virtue of their design. They have an IPX4 rating, which is sadly nowhere close to what you get with other products in the price range or lower.

In terms of the app, these use the Sony Headphones Connect app. To sum it up in a single line, it has most of what you could ask for, including custom EQ controls, option to modify the touch controls, and more.

PERFORMANCE

The Sony LinkBuds live up to the expectations that we had set, especially considering price and the fact that they are made by Sony. The soundstage is wide, and instrument separation is great on this pair. The cherry on top is Sony's Digital Sound Enhancement Engine (DSEE) that fills in all the gaps in the earbuds' sound quality. However, the bass response

was not that great. It sounded muddy and brought down the listening experience in tracks that are laden with bass instruments. The mids and the highs were as we expected them to be.

Now, coming to the microphone performance. Once again, Sony lives up to the standards that they have set for themselves. The audio coming from the microphones is crisp and could be heard with ease by the person at the other end.



BATTERY LIFE

The LinkBuds lasted long during our tests. It took us close to five and half hours at 50 per cent volume to drain the battery of the buds. The case promises to give the buds another 12 hours of juice, which pegs the total battery life at about 17.5 hours in total. So you should get through a couple of days of usage with these. The company is also claiming that with just 10 minutes of charge you can get a listening time of 90 minutes.

VERDICT

The Sony LinkBuds are unique, which means a lot of things. Firstly, there is no product that you can pit them against. Owning these buds is a unique experience, that cannot be matched by the offerings of any other brand. What you earn in terms of style points and unique design and features, you lose out in the form of modern-day essentials like ANC. So, if you are out in the market with a ₹20k budget, and want to try out something new, then go for it. However, if you are looking for anything close to a bang for the buck experience, then stay away from these.

—Sativik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

WEIGHT (EARBUDS): Approx. 41 g x 2 | HEADPHONE TYPE: Open, Dynamic | FREQUENCY RESPONSE: 20 Hz-20 kHz | IP RATING: Yes (IPX4) | BATTERY LIFE (EARBUDS): Max. 5.5 hrs | BLUETOOTH VERSION: 5.2 | EFFECTIVE RANGE: 10 m | SUPPORTED AUDIO CODEC(S): SBC, AAC

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